

What happens when an AI demo proves capability, but not adoption value?

192K employees were preparing to demonstrate Galaxy AI. I thought the flagship use case was going to fail.

- AI and Technology Experience
- Transformation Experience
- Business Results

The technology worked. That was the problem.

The proposed documentation was technically impressive: “Find a vegan Italian restaurant with outdoor seating that’s also pet friendly.”

It showcased AI working across applications. But I kept coming back to one question: **What happens when someone tries this in Kansas?** A demo doesn’t build confidence if the employee can’t reliably reproduce it.

So I proposed something different.

The launch was happening around the Super Bowl. I wanted to preserve the cross-app magic while making the experience relevant almost anywhere.

THE PROPOSED DEMO
Vegan + Italian + outdoor seating + pet friendly

✓ Technically sophisticated

✓ Multi-app

✗ Geography dependent

✗ Unpredictable

MY RECOMMENDATION
Find healthy Super Bowl appetizers, add the ingredients to my grocery list

Same AI. Better human use case.

✓ Technically sophisticated

✓ Multi-app

✓ Broadly relevant

✓ Repeatable

They went with the original.
And the failure mode I’d worried about started happening. “I couldn’t find any restaurants.” Eventually, some employees stopped demonstrating the feature.

What I did next.
I was transitioning to Walmart, but knew my team would be looked to for feedback. I documented what happened, captured the adoption risks and recommendations in the launch post-mortem, and left them with my team and leader.

AT A GLANCE

192K employees

Multi-company launch

Multi-geography launch

Emerging AI technology

WHY THIS STORY

I’m willing to challenge an exciting idea before everyone else knows whether it will work. I’d rather surface an adoption risk early than stay quiet because the technology itself is impressive.

This story also demonstrates:

Strategic influence

Adoption and behavior change

Risk assessment

Go-to-market execution

Change leadership

IF WE TALK, ASK ME ABOUT

➤ What made me confident the original use case would struggle at scale.

➤ How I balanced technical impressiveness with real-world adoption.

➤ The feedback I heard after launch.

➤ The tradeoffs between showing what AI can do and what people will actually repeat.

➤ How local and enterprise leadership responded to pushback, and my response.

WHAT I'M PROUD OF

I spoke up before launch. I knew how hard our teams had worked to establish credibility - both from a curriculum development perspective and being “boots on the ground” in retail stores. I wanted them to know their voices mattered and I was listening.

MY GUIDING PRINCIPLE

Clarity is part of adoption. Give people a repeatable experience and clear path, or expect inconsistency and deprioritization.

IF I HAD A DO-OVER

I wouldn’t necessarily change my recommendation. I’d ask questions earlier:

- Which decisions about the HOW are actually open for us to make?
- Could we establish back up plans for questions in case there are demonstration issues?